

I really don't like the word consciousness but I don't know of a better one. Or rather I worry that using a different one just leaves the questions open. It's been easy in the past to 'redefine-away' answers to questions that we didn't like. AI often does that. Can't remember who it was who said that when we don't know how to do it, it's 'artificial intelligence'; once we do, it's just 'automation'!

For my part I think there are many kinds of consciousness. I don't even know what it's like to be a woman, let alone an alien, but I recognize that women are conscious. At least, they tell me they are.

Do plants have a sense of identity? Well, I think that MIGHT be two separate questions, or more, but I can't quite tease them apart well enough to explain very well what I mean. I often think about thermostats: they are 'aware' of how hot the room is. They are also 'aware' of what they've previously done about it (have they turned the heating on yet or not?), and so they are 'self-aware'. They even 'intend' to keep the room at the right temperature. They have no choice, but then none of us do either - we just believe we do. This is all just true. But clearly they don't THINK about any of this, and they have no mechanism to FEEL one way or the other about it - they don't feel sad if the room won't get warm/cool enough; they don't get embarrassed if they forget to turn the heating on, etc., etc.

I think it's this ability to think and to feel that is the important part of what we usually mean by being conscious. And there are many levels of thought and feeling. Some of us have some of them but not others. Some might not even be our property, even though we're cogs in its wheel (I'm thinking collective consciousness). Cows seem to me like quite emotional creatures, and they seem to think in some ways, but I doubt they have long-term plans and worry about their retirement.

Thinking AND feeling are about the future and past. It's the ability to disconnect from the present that enables us to think. Without being able to step back, we're no different from a thermostat, which just 'is'. And most emotions are not so much felt at the time but felt in the future or past. When I feel sad, it seems like I'm sad in the present, right now, and yet it's the very essence of sadness that it's about something that happened or didn't happen or might or might not happen. Anxiety is 100% about things that haven't happened yet. Sometimes there are multiple layers of time - worry is fear in advance; fear is pain in advance. Pain, oddly, isn't even really pain in the present - it's more painful after it has happened. I've sliced my finger with countless sharp objects over the years and I didn't feel the cut; I felt pain ABOUT the cut, if you see what I mean.

So it's this ability to disconnect from the present, and experience things that haven't happened yet, or re-experience things that already happened (and learn from them for the future) that I'm interested in as consciousness. Thermostats are aware but don't

know they're aware. Same with plants, almost certainly. And the same with many animals, too. But this ability to disengage comes on-stream one step at a time. I've spent my whole life anxious about the future in ways that cows probably don't have to worry about. But cows have other levels of consciousness and seem to be happy when they're let out and anxious when milking time comes round and the farmer is late. I think there are probably many shades of gray, but each shade requires its own specialized equipment.